



Rooted rise: Once she tilled the fields alongside her father. Now Marufa ploughs through batting line-ups with pace and swing.

ARIFA JAHAN BITHI/FACEBOOK

in Rangpur — brought Marufa into national focus.

In one of them, wearing a yellow puffer jacket, Marufa and her father are seen ploughing their paddy field. By then she had already been scouted, but the pandemic halted training and funding, threatening to end her career even before it began. Though Arifa never formally trained her, she has remained a constant supporter and sounding board.

Arifa trains over 350 girls across various age groups and knows firsthand how rare a talent like Marufa is.

“Marufa has a background of working very hard in the fields since childhood. She is a good athlete, a natural athlete, and that amount of hard work is normal for people like her and has held her in good standing. Watching her remove those two batters in the first over gave me goosebumps. That kind of pace bowling I have not seen from a player from this nation,” she told *Sportstar*.

For a simple farming family surviving on leased land, Marufa’s

rise has been life-changing. But what means most to her is the shift in her father’s outlook. “My family was not very supportive because my father is a farmer, so he wanted me to get a normal job. But day by day, when I started doing well, my family started supporting me very much,” she had said earlier, with Joty translating for her.

The league life

From being spotted by Mohammedan Sporting Club at a trial aged 15 and joining the *Bangladesh Krira Shikkha Protishtan* to becoming the national team’s pace spearhead, Marufa’s journey has been as fulfilling to watch as it has been to live.

Once a shy teenager who poured all her energy into cricket, negotiating savings and societal expectations to make accommodations for her dream, she is now an assured, smiling competitor who needs no translator, delivers sharp one-liners, and relishes taking on the biggest names in the game.

When asked if she wanted to feature in leagues such as the Women’s Premier League (WPL) or the Women’s Big Bash League (WBBL), Marufa turned uncertainly to the media manager beside her, who steered clear of franchise talk.

Shared triumph: Arifa Jahan Bithi, who first spotted Marufa’s spark in Rangpur, shares a proud smile with Bangladesh’s rising pace star.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Whether she’s ready for that leap or not, those who have seen her bowl believe the step is only a matter of time.

“I think Marufa’s talent should travel to the WPL and WBBL. There are very few players in this franchise circuit from Bangladesh. We’ve had Rumana Ahmed and Jahanara Alam feature abroad, but if more girls find opportunities, it will inspire the rest,” Arifa said.

“How she started in this World Cup will and should attract franchises,” Joty added. “This way, she will get more exposure in the sport. But right now, she should focus on the World Cup. She needs to take care of building strength physically and mentally. She’s very young and has a unique action. She needs things to be done to be ready for cricket on that level.”

For now, Marufa’s mantra stays simple. “It’s always me vs me and not me vs others,” she said — a gentle warning to those yet to face her in the World Cup.

The cricketing world, for one, can’t wait.